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1 Central Claims

- European party systems of the 1960s are not primarily responses to contemporary social divisions; they are the institutionalized residue of **cleavage structures** generated by two great historical transformations—the **National Revolution** and the **Industrial Revolution**—as those cleavages were translated into organized political alternatives during the era of mass suffrage extension (roughly 1870–1920).
- Four fundamental cleavages are generated by these revolutions: (1) **center vs. periphery** (subject populations vs. nation-building elites), (2) **state vs. church** (secularizing nation-state vs. historically privileged corporate church), (3) **land vs. industry** (agrarian interests vs. rising urban-industrial entrepreneurs), and (4) **owner vs. worker** (capital vs. labor). The first two derive from the National Revolution, the latter two from the Industrial Revolution.
- The famous “**freezing**” **hypothesis**: “the party systems of the 1960’s reflect, with few but significant exceptions, the cleavage structures of the 1920’s”—party alternatives, once organizationally consolidated around a mobilized electorate, became remarkably stable, so that the party systems most West European voters faced in the 1960s were essentially the same alternatives their grandparents faced at the point of full enfranchisement.
- Cleavages are not reducible to objective social-structural divisions alone. A cleavage becomes politically consequential only when it has three components: an **empirical** basis (an identifiable social division), a **normative** element (a shared sense of identity/interest, a set of values legitimating the division), and an **organizational** expression (parties, unions, churches, and associations that mobilize and represent the division). Social difference becomes political cleavage only through organization.
- Cross-national variation in party systems results from variation in the **sequencing and combination** of critical junctures (Reformation/Counter-Reformation, National Revolution, Industrial Revolution) and from the different ways nation-building elites responded to the resulting cleavages—not from variation in “modernization” levels alone.
- Party systems are the product of a translation process: cleavages in the social structure are filtered through political entrepreneurs, alliance strategies, and—crucially—**electoral institutions** (particularly the shift from majoritarian to proportional representation) before they crystallize into a given number and configuration of durable parties.

2 Core Concepts and Analytic Framework

- **Cleavage vs. division**: Lipset and Rokkan deliberately distinguish a “cleavage” from a mere social division or conflict of interest. A cleavage requires the tripartite structure noted above (empirical, normative, organizational); this is the concept’s most frequently cited and most frequently contested analytic contribution.

- **The two revolutions:** The **National Revolution**—the consolidation of centralized nation-states out of dynastic and local units, accompanied by cultural standardization (language, education, administration)—produces the center-periphery and state-church cleavages. The **Industrial Revolution**—the shift from agrarian to industrial-capitalist economies—produces the land-industry and owner-worker cleavages.
- **Critical junctures:** Historical turning points (the Reformation, the National Revolution, the Industrial Revolution, the Russian Revolution/international Communist split) generate cleavages whose resolution sets subsequent political development on a path that is difficult to reverse—an early and influential statement of what later scholars would call **path dependence** and **critical juncture** analysis in historical institutionalism.
- **The four “thresholds”** a political movement must cross to become a fully institutionalized party within a competitive system:
 1. **Legitimation**—the right to petition, criticize, and organize opposition is recognized rather than suppressed.
 2. **Incorporation**—the movement’s supporters win the right to participate in the selection of representatives (suffrage extension).
 3. **Representation**—the movement can win seats, which requires either a lowering of formal barriers (deposits, district magnitude) or an accommodation of its organizational strategy to the existing electoral system.
 4. **Majority power**—the movement’s party can plausibly compete for and win governing power, not merely a minority voice.

Countries and movements crossed these thresholds at different rates and in different sequences, producing very different party system outcomes (e.g., early vs. late enfranchisement of labor movements).

- **The 1:4:2 “translation” model:** cleavage → movement → party is not automatic; it depends on “the constitution” (electoral laws), the strategies of pre-existing elites, and alliance possibilities among cleavage groups. This is where Lipset and Rokkan anticipate later work (Duverger, and subsequently Cox 1997) on the mechanical and psychological effects of electoral systems on party-system fragmentation.
- **Cross-cutting vs. reinforcing cleavages:** where the four cleavages cut across one another (e.g., a Catholic working class divided between confessional and class appeals), party systems tend toward greater fragmentation and cross-pressured voters; where cleavages reinforce one another, party systems polarize along fewer, deeper lines. This builds on cross-pressure/cross-cleavage theorizing already present in the Columbia School voting-behavior tradition (Lazarsfeld, Berelson, and Gaudet).
- **Freezing mechanisms:** mass parties, once built, develop organizational interests in their own survival (party bureaucracies, allied unions and churches, mass membership identities) that persist independent of the social conditions that originally produced them—an

argument about **organizational path dependence** that parallels Michels’s “iron law of oligarchy” and anticipates historical-institutionalist arguments about increasing returns.

3 Core Works Cited

- **Maurice Duverger**, *Political Parties* (1951/1954)—the direct predecessor on electoral-law effects on party systems (Duverger’s Law/Hypothesis); Lipset and Rokkan build directly on Duverger’s mechanical/psychological distinction in discussing how electoral systems mediate the cleavage-to-party translation.
- **Reinhard Bendix**, *Nation-Building and Citizenship* (1964)—provides the comparative-historical framework for the National Revolution and the sequential extension of citizenship rights that Lipset and Rokkan adapt into their “thresholds” schema.
- **Talcott Parsons** and structural-functionalist sociology—the underlying theoretical vocabulary (differentiation, integration) for treating the National and Industrial Revolutions as functional imperatives that societies must resolve.
- **Otto Kirchheimer**—on the “catch-all party” and the decline of ideological mass parties; Lipset and Rokkan engage the question of whether postwar affluence was dissolving the cleavage basis of European parties, and largely (though not unconditionally) reject this thesis for the period under study.
- **Paul Lazarsfeld, Bernard Berelson, and Hazel Gaudet**, *The People’s Choice* (1944), and the Columbia School voting-behavior tradition—the micro-level foundation (social determination of the vote, cross-pressures) on which Lipset and Rokkan build a macro-historical, cross-national argument.
- **Robert Michels**, *Political Parties* (1911)—the “iron law of oligarchy” underlies the freezing hypothesis’s account of why party organizations, once built, resist dissolution even as their original social base erodes.
- **Lipset’s own** *Political Man* (1960)—many of the cross-national correlations (class voting, religious voting, regional voting) synthesized here draw on Lipset’s earlier comparative electoral sociology.
- The volume’s own country chapters (by Rokkan on Norway, Allardt and Pesonen on Finland, Lorwin on Belgium, Rokkan and Valen, and others)—the introduction is explicitly a synthesizing framework for the empirical chapters that follow in the edited volume; the argument is best read as an interpretive scaffold for those cases, not a free-standing theory tested independently of them.

4 The Two Revolutions and the Four Cleavages

- **Center-periphery (National Revolution):** nation-building elites at the political and cultural center impose standardized language, administration, and often religion on peripheral populations with distinct ethnic, linguistic, or regional identities. Where peripheral resistance is strong and sustained (e.g., linguistic minorities, historic regions), it generates regionalist/ethnic parties and durable territorial cleavages.
- **State-church (National Revolution):** the secularizing, standardizing nation-state clashes with the church over control of core social functions—above all education, marriage, and the legal status of religious corporate privileges. Where the clash is sharp (Catholic countries with strong confessional mobilization), it produces confessional/clerical vs. secular/anticlerical party cleavages that cross-cut class lines and often blunt the strength of pure class parties.
- **Land-industry (Industrial Revolution):** rising commercial-industrial elites confront landed agrarian interests over trade policy, taxation, and political representation. This cleavage produces agrarian/peasant parties (strong in Scandinavia) that persist as a distinct party family separate from both liberal/urban and labor/socialist parties.
- **Owner-worker (Industrial Revolution):** the paradigmatic class cleavage between capital and organized labor, producing socialist/labor/communist parties as the industrial working class is progressively incorporated and enfranchised. This is the cleavage most familiar to non-specialists and the one most directly engaged by later class-voting and political-economy literatures, but Lipset and Rokkan insist it must be understood as only one of four, not the master cleavage to which others reduce.
- **Sequencing produces variation:** because countries experienced the Reformation, National Revolution, and Industrial Revolution in different orders, with different degrees of overlap, and under different religious configurations (Catholic vs. Protestant vs. religiously mixed), the same four underlying cleavage types combine into markedly different national party systems—e.g., strong confessional parties where state-church conflict was unresolved before mass enfranchisement of labor (e.g., the Netherlands, Belgium, parts of Germany) vs. purer class-based two-party or two-bloc systems where the state-church cleavage had been resolved earlier or was largely absent (e.g., Britain, and to a lesser degree the Scandinavian countries).

5 From Cleavage to Party System: Thresholds and Electoral Mediation

- The translation of cleavage into party system is not mechanical. A social cleavage can exist for decades without producing a durable party if it fails to cross the legitimization and incorporation thresholds—suppression of the labor movement, restricted suffrage, or elite fusion tactics can delay or block party formation.

- Even after incorporation, the **representation threshold** is shaped heavily by electoral rules: majoritarian/plurality systems raise the effective threshold for new movements to win seats, encouraging consolidation into a small number of broad parties (or absorption of new cleavages into existing party “umbrellas”), while proportional representation—adopted across much of continental Europe in the early twentieth century partly *in response to* rising socialist and confessional mobilization—lowers that threshold and permits cleavage-based parties to survive as distinct, persistent organizations.
- This is the essay’s most direct nod to what would become the Duvergerian/Coxian institutionalist research program: electoral systems are not neutral transmission belts but actively shape how many cleavage-based alternatives survive into the party system, and once adopted, PR itself becomes part of the “freezing” mechanism by protecting smaller cleavage parties from extinction.
- The **majority-power threshold** determines whether a cleavage-based party remains a permanent minority (protest party, junior coalition partner) or becomes a plausible party of government—this shapes both the party’s internal moderation incentives and the broader system’s degree of polarization.
- Once movements have crossed all four thresholds and built mass organizations (party bureaucracies, affiliated unions, confessional associations, youth wings, party press), the cost of dissolving or fundamentally realigning around new cleavages becomes very high—the organizational infrastructure itself, not just voter identity, freezes the system in place.

6 The Freezing Hypothesis

- The core empirical claim: by the time of full mass enfranchisement (roughly the 1920s in most of Western Europe), the major cleavage lines had been translated into stable party alternatives, and the party systems of the 1960s—forty years and enormous socioeconomic change later—remained recognizably the same in terms of the number and identity of major party families.
- Mechanisms proposed for freezing: (1) organizational consolidation (mass party bureaucracies, affiliated interest organizations) that outlives the social conditions that produced it; (2) the socialization of voters into partisan identities transmitted across generations within families and communities; (3) electoral laws (especially PR) that protect smaller established parties from being squeezed out; (4) the sheer difficulty of a new cleavage acquiring the full empirical-normative-organizational structure needed to displace an already-organized alternative.
- Lipset and Rokkan are careful to frame this as a claim about the *alternatives available to voters*, not about the stability of individual party vote shares—parties could gain and lose vote share considerably while the basic cleavage structure and party *families* remained constant.

- The freezing thesis is explicitly historically bounded: it describes Western Europe from mass enfranchisement (1920s) through the observed present (1960s) and does not claim that party systems are frozen forever; the authors note pressures (affluence, the “end of ideology” debates, generational change) that could eventually unfreeze alignments, without predicting exactly when or how.

7 Methodological Contributions and Limitations

- **Contribution—macro-historical comparative framework:** the essay is one of the founding statements of historical-institutionalist comparative politics, showing how long-run historical processes (revolutions, critical junctures) can be systematically compared across cases to explain contemporary institutional variation, rather than relying on synchronic modernization indices alone.
- **Contribution—conceptual precision on “cleavage”:** the empirical/normative/organizational tripartite definition remains the standard reference point in cleavage theory; it forces analysts to distinguish social structure, group identity, and political organization as analytically separate (if empirically linked) components.
- **Contribution—bridge between sociology and institutionalism:** the essay explicitly connects social-structural cleavage formation to institutional variables (electoral rules, thresholds), anticipating the later synthesis of sociological and rational-institutionalist approaches to party systems.
- **Limitation—looseness of “critical junctures”:** the sequencing argument is suggestive and richly illustrated with cases but is not formalized; it is difficult to generate ex ante predictions about which sequences produce which outcomes, and the framework has been criticized (e.g., by later historical institutionalists such as Capoccia and Kelemen) for undertheorizing what makes a juncture “critical” and how contingency operates within it.
- **Limitation—data and case selection:** the argument is built almost entirely from a small number of Western European cases (chosen partly because they are the volume’s country-chapter cases); its generalizability outside Western Europe (and outside stable, competitive democracies) is untested within the essay itself.
- **Limitation—the freezing thesis dates quickly:** written at almost the exact historical moment (the late 1960s) that European party systems began to unfreeze—the rise of New Left and green/post-materialist parties, the erosion of class and religious voting, and eventually populist realignment all began within a decade or two of publication, giving the thesis an unfortunate reputation for being falsified almost immediately after being proposed (though defenders note the authors themselves flagged possible unfreezing pressures).

8 Critiques and Later Revisions of the Freezing Thesis

- **Dealignment literature:** beginning in the 1970s–80s (Dalton, Flanagan, and Beck’s *Electoral Change in Advanced Industrial Democracies*, 1984), scholars documented weakening ties between social class/religion and party choice across advanced democracies, directly challenging the freezing thesis’s premise of stable, cleavage-anchored voter alignments.
- **Ronald Inglehart and post-materialism:** Inglehart’s *The Silent Revolution* (1977) and subsequent work argue that generational value change (from materialist to post-materialist priorities: environment, self-expression, participation) introduced a genuinely new cleavage dimension not derivable from the four Lipset-Rokkan cleavages, giving rise to Green parties and New Left formations that the original framework cannot easily accommodate.
- **Realignment and new cleavages:** subsequent scholarship (Kriesi et al. on a new “integration-demarcation” or globalization cleavage; the broader populist-radical-right literature) argues that globalization, immigration, and European integration have generated a cleavage structurally analogous to Lipset and Rokkan’s center-periphery/national cleavage but organized around new lines (cosmopolitan/open vs. nationalist/closed), producing a genuine restructuring rather than mere “defrosting” of the old system.
- **Defenders of the freezing thesis** (e.g., Bartolini and Mair, *Identity, Competition, and Electoral Availability*, 1990) argue that aggregate electoral volatility in Western Europe remained comparatively low through the late twentieth century, suggesting the freeze persisted longer and more robustly than dealignment theorists claimed, even as its foundations shifted.
- **The broader lesson:** the freezing hypothesis has proven most valuable not as a permanent empirical claim but as a framework that clarifies what would need to change for party systems to realign—a new social cleavage must acquire empirical, normative, and organizational reality and cross the same four thresholds (legitimation, incorporation, representation, majority power) that nineteenth-century movements had to cross.

9 Connections to the Broader Literature

- **Cox 1997, *Making Votes Count*:** the most direct downstream connection. Cox formalizes and generalizes exactly the mechanism Lipset and Rokkan gesture toward informally—how electoral rules (district magnitude, ballot structure) determine how many parties a given set of social cleavages can support. Where Lipset and Rokkan treat electoral systems as one mediating factor among several in a historical narrative, Cox provides the rational-choice microfoundations (strategic voting and entry, the M+1 rule) for why PR permits more cleavage-based parties to survive than plurality rule does—in effect, Cox answers with formal precision the question Lipset and Rokkan pose narratively about the “representation threshold.”

- **Duverger (via Lipset and Rokkan) and Lijphart 1999:** Lijphart’s distinction between majoritarian and consensus democracies, and his empirical linkage of electoral system type to party-system fragmentation and to the number/depth of cross-cutting societal cleavages (his “federal-unitary” and cultural homogeneity dimensions), operationalizes and extends the cleavage-institution linkage Lipset and Rokkan first sketched. Lijphart’s “plural societies” requiring consociational arrangements are essentially societies with strong, reinforcing, unresolved center-periphery/state-church/class cleavages of the type Lipset and Rokkan describe.
- **Huntington 1968, *Political Order in Changing Societies*:** both works treat institutionalization as the central variable explaining political stability, but they diverge sharply in mechanism and normative valence. Huntington worries that rapid mobilization outpacing institutional capacity produces decay and praetorianism in developing states; Lipset and Rokkan describe a case (Western Europe) where mobilization and institutionalization proceeded roughly in tandem, producing durable (frozen) rather than decaying institutions. Read together, they suggest that the sequencing and pacing of mobilization relative to institution-building—not mobilization or institutionalization per se—determines whether the outcome is a Lipset-Rokkan-style frozen party system or a Huntington-style praetorian breakdown.
- **Moore 1966, *Social Origins of Dictatorship and Democracy*:** both are macro-historical, critical-juncture-style accounts of how the transition out of agrarian society shapes modern political regimes. Moore focuses on the class coalitions (landed elite, bourgeoisie, peasantry) that determine regime type (democracy, fascism, communism); Lipset and Rokkan focus on how the same underlying agrarian-industrial and elite-mass tensions get channeled into party systems *within* already-democratizing polities. Moore’s land-labor coalition analysis is close kin to Lipset and Rokkan’s land-industry and owner-worker cleavages, and both works treat the historical sequencing of socioeconomic transformation as decisive for later political outcomes.
- **Dahl 1972, *Polyarchy*:** Dahl’s twin dimensions of contestation and inclusiveness map loosely onto Lipset and Rokkan’s thresholds—incorporation is essentially Dahl’s inclusiveness, while legitimation and representation correspond to Dahl’s contestation. Lipset and Rokkan provide the cleavage-driven historical content (which groups were incorporated, in what order, around what social divisions) that gives texture to Dahl’s more abstract, dimensional account of democratization.
- **Weber 1930 (and Weber more broadly):** the state-church cleavage and the treatment of religious cultural legacies as durable, path-dependent political forces echo Weber’s method (if not his specific thesis in *The Protestant Ethic*) of tracing contemporary institutional/political patterns to religious-cultural origins. Both works treat Protestant/Catholic confessional divisions as consequential for the trajectory of political and economic development, though Lipset and Rokkan focus on party organization rather than the spirit of capitalism.
- **Putnam 1993, *Making Democracy Work*:** both works are exercises in explain-

ing contemporary political variation via long-run historical path dependence (medieval communal traditions for Putnam; Reformation-era and National Revolution cleavages for Lipset and Rokkan), and both emphasize that organizational/associational structures, once established, persist and shape outcomes long after their originating conditions have changed. Putnam’s civic community is, in a sense, the social-capital analogue to Lipset and Rokkan’s frozen cleavage organizations—both are “sticky” social infrastructures resistant to short-run reform.

- **Huber and Shipan 2002:** a much more distant connection, but both works are concerned with how political conflict gets encoded into durable institutional form—Huber and Shipan on how policy conflict is written into statutory language and delegation, Lipset and Rokkan on how social conflict is written into party organization. Both treat institutionalization as a response to underlying conflict that then constrains future political actors.
- **Powell 2000, *Elections as Instruments of Democracy*:** Powell’s comparison of proportional-influence versus majoritarian visions of democratic representation builds on the same electoral-system consequences Lipset and Rokkan flag; Powell’s empirical work on congruence between voter preferences and government policy can be read as asking whether the frozen, cleavage-based party systems Lipset and Rokkan describe actually deliver good representation of the cleavages they encode.
- **Stokes 2013 and Svolik 2012:** both are more distant, focusing respectively on clientelism/distributive politics and authoritarian institutions rather than Western European mass-party cleavage structures; the connection is mainly by contrast—Lipset and Rokkan’s account presupposes exactly the kind of programmatic, cleavage-based party competition that clientelistic linkage strategies (Stokes) substitute for in many developing democracies, while Svolik’s authoritarian power-sharing institutions represent an entirely different institutional response to elite and mass conflict than the competitive party organizations Lipset and Rokkan analyze.
- **Carey 2009, *Legislative Voting and Accountability*:** connects at the level of party organization—Carey’s account of how electoral and legislative rules shape party cohesion and legislators’ incentives to toe the party line is a natural extension of Lipset and Rokkan’s interest in how institutionalized mass parties, once frozen, discipline and channel political behavior long after their cleavage origins.